

Good Intentions Are Not Enough

The death of Uzzah in **2 Samuel 6** teaches an important lesson about approaching God. When the Ark of the Covenant began to fall from the cart, Uzzah reached out to steady it. His action appeared sincere and practical. Yet God struck him dead. The problem was not simply that he touched the Ark. The problem began earlier. God had already revealed that the Ark was to be carried by Levites using poles, not transported on a cart (**Numbers 4:15; 7:9**). David later admitted their mistake: “we did not seek him according to the prescribed ordinance” (**1 Chronicles 15:13**).

This pattern appears throughout Scripture. Nadab and Abihu offered unauthorized fire in worship. Saul spared the Amalekite livestock so he could offer sacrifices. Moses struck the rock instead of speaking to it. Jeroboam established new places and forms of worship for political convenience. In each case, people pursued good objectives by methods God had not authorized. Their failure was not a lack of zeal. It was replacing God’s revealed will with human judgment.

The same warning continues in the New Testament. Jesus condemned worship that followed human traditions instead of God’s commands (**Mark 7:6–9**). Paul taught that Christians are called to **“the obedience of faith”** (**Romans 1:5**). Faith is more than belief. It trusts God enough to obey what He has revealed, even when another way seems easier or more effective.

The lesson is clear. God does not ask His people to invent better ways to serve Him. He asks them to trust Him. Sincerity, good intentions, and successful results cannot replace obedience. Worship and teaching must begin with the question, *“What has God said?”* When God’s will is known through His Word, faith responds by doing what He has commanded rather than what seems best in human eyes.

The central question of worship and teaching is not, *“Will this work?”* or *“Do we mean well?”* The central question is, *“Has God spoken?”* This is the **“obedience of faith”** that frames Paul’s teaching in Romans. Faith does not invent its own path to God. Faith hears God’s word, trusts His wisdom, and walks in the way He has revealed.

Uzzah and the Ark: When Good Intentions Are Not Enough

Introduction

The death of Uzzah is one of the most difficult events in Scripture. At first glance, it appears unfair. A man reaches out to steady the Ark of the Covenant. His intention seems honorable. Yet God strikes him dead immediately.

The account is not primarily about touching a sacred object. It is about approaching God on human terms rather than His terms.

The larger biblical pattern is this: **People often substitute human wisdom, good intentions, or practical methods for obedience to God's revealed will.**

The story of Uzzah becomes a key example of a principle that appears throughout both the Old and New Testaments.

The Historical Setting

David desired to bring the Ark to Jerusalem.

2 Samuel 6:2–3 (NET)

“David and all the men who were with him traveled to Baalah in Judah to bring up from there the ark of God... They loaded the ark of God on a new cart...”

A “new cart” probably seemed respectful.

It was clean.

It was expensive.

It was practical.

It also directly violated God's instructions.

God's Earlier Instructions

The Law had already specified exactly how the Ark was to be transported.

Numbers 4:15 (NET)

“After Aaron and his sons have finished covering the sanctuary and all the furnishings of the sanctuary, when the camp is ready to journey, then the Kohathites are to come to carry them; but they must not touch any holy thing, or they will die.”

The Ark was not to be touched.

Numbers 7:9 (NET)

“But to the Kohathites he gave none because they were responsible for the sanctuary service; they carried the holy things on their shoulders.”

No carts.

No oxen.

The Ark belonged on the shoulders of the Levites.

Exodus 25:13–15 (NET)

God commanded rings and poles to remain permanently attached to the Ark.

Why?

Because it was never intended to be handled directly.

What Went Wrong?

The problem did not begin when Uzzah touched the Ark. It began when David chose the cart. The touch merely exposed an earlier failure.

David later recognized this.

1 Chronicles 15:13 (NET)

“The first time you did not carry it; that is why the LORD our God attacked us, because we did not seek him according to the prescribed ordinance.”

This statement explains the entire event.

Not: “We lacked sincerity.”

Not: “Our motives were wrong.”

But: **“We did not seek Him according to the prescribed ordinance.”**

The issue was obedience.

Why Did Uzzah Reach Out?

Humanly speaking, Uzzah did the obvious thing.

The Ark was tipping.

He tried to save it.

But the irony is striking.

He assumed:

“My hand is cleaner than the dirt.”

Scripture teaches the opposite.

Human hands are unclean because of sin.

The earth God created was never morally corrupt.
The greater danger was not that the Ark might touch dirt.
The greater danger was that sinful man presumed authority over God's holiness.

David's Response

David was first angry.

2 Samuel 6:8 (NET)

"David was angry because the LORD attacked Uzzah..."

Then David became afraid.

Verse 9

"How will the ark of the LORD ever come to me?"

Only later did David seek God's revealed instruction.

Then everything changed.

The Second Attempt

1 Chronicles 15

David assembled the Levites.
He sanctified them.
He used the poles.
He followed the Law.
The difference was not enthusiasm.
It was obedience.

A Repeating Biblical Pattern

Uzzah is not unique.
Scripture repeatedly shows sincere people substituting human judgment for God's revealed will.

Nadab and Abihu

Leviticus 10:1–3

Aaron's sons offered "strange fire."
Scripture never questions their sincerity.
Their worship violated God's command.
God consumed them.

Verse 3 (NET)

“Among the ones close to me I will show myself holy, and in the presence of all the people I will be honored.”

Worship does not belong to the worshiper.
God determines acceptable worship.

Saul and the Amalekites

1 Samuel 15

Saul spared the best animals.
His stated purpose?
Sacrifice.

1 Samuel 15:21 (NET)

“...to sacrifice to the LORD your God...”
His intention sounded religious.
Samuel answered:

1 Samuel 15:22 (NET)

“Does the LORD take pleasure in burnt offerings and sacrifices as much as he does in obedience?
Certainly, obedience is better than sacrifice...”
This may be the clearest Old Testament statement of the principle.

Saul Offering Sacrifice

1 Samuel 13

Samuel delayed.
The army scattered.
Saul acted.
It seemed practical.
It also violated God’s order.
The kingdom was taken from him.
Urgency never authorizes disobedience.

Moses Striking the Rock

Numbers 20

God said:
Speak to the rock.
Moses struck it.
Water still came.
The miracle happened.
Yet Moses lost entrance into Canaan.

Even successful results cannot justify disobedience.

Jeroboam's Worship

1 Kings 12

Jeroboam feared losing political control.
His solution seemed practical.
He made alternate worship centers.
Golden calves.
New feast days.
New priests.
His changes solved political problems.
They became "the sin of Jeroboam."
Pragmatism replaced revelation.

King Uzziah

2 Chronicles 26

A successful king decided to burn incense.
The priests warned him.
He ignored them.
God struck him with leprosy.
Good leadership in one area did not authorize changes in worship.

New Testament Examples

Ananias and Sapphira

Acts 5

They wanted the appearance of devotion.
Their worship contained deception.
God judged immediately.

Simon the Magician

Acts 8

He wanted spiritual power.
He attempted to obtain God's gift by worldly means.
Peter condemned the attempt.

The Corinthians

1 Corinthians 11

The church gathered for the Lord's Supper.

They still ate bread.

They still drank the cup.

But Paul says:

"When you come together, it is not the Lord's Supper you eat." (1 Corinthians 11:20, NET)

The external form remained.

The heart and practice violated God's purpose.

Jesus and Human Tradition

Perhaps the strongest New Testament parallel comes from Jesus Himself.

Mark 7:6–9 (NET)

"These people honor me with their lips, but their heart is far from me. They worship me in vain, teaching as doctrines the commandments of men."

Notice the progression.

Human ideas

become

religious tradition

which becomes

false worship.

Jesus does not condemn sincerity.

He condemns replacing God's commands.

Teaching the Same Principle

Paul repeatedly warns against this tendency.

Colossians 2:20–23

Human regulations often appear wise.

Paul says they have "an appearance of wisdom."

Appearance is not authority.

2 Timothy 4:3–4

People accumulate teachers

who tell them

what they want to hear.

Pragmatism replaces truth.

Galatians 1:6–9

Even sincere teachers must not preach another gospel.

Truth is determined by God's revelation.

Not by intention.

Why Do People Do This?

The Bible suggests several reasons.

1. Human wisdom feels more practical.

A cart is easier than poles.

Organization often seems more efficient than obedience.

2. Visible results become the measure of success.

If it works,

people assume God approves.

Scripture never teaches that.

3. People confuse sincerity with faith.

Sincerity is valuable.

But sincerity alone does not define truth.

Paul himself admitted this.

Acts 23:1 (NET)

"I have lived my life with a clear conscience before God to this day."

Yet before becoming a Christian he persecuted Christ's church.

His conscience had been sincere.

It had not been correct.

4. People assume the end justifies the means.

This is one of humanity's oldest temptations.

If the objective is good,

surely God approves the method.

Scripture consistently rejects this reasoning.

The Obedience of Faith

Paul introduces Romans with a striking phrase.

Romans 1:5 (NET)

“...to bring about the obedience of faith among all the Gentiles...”

He closes the letter the same way.

Romans 16:26 (NET)

“...to bring about the obedience of faith.”

Faith is not merely believing.

Faith submits.

Faith obeys.

Faith asks,

“What has God said?”

before asking,

“What seems best?”

What Does God Want?

The consistent biblical answer is remarkably simple.

God desires trust expressed through obedience.

1 Samuel 15:22

Obedience is better than sacrifice.

Micah 6:6–8

Not multiplied offerings,

but justice,

mercy,

and humble walking with God.

John 14:15 (NET)

“If you love me, you will obey my commandments.”

Love expresses itself in obedience.

Hebrews 11

Every example of faith follows the same pattern.

God speaks.

People believe Him.

They obey what He said.

Faith always acts upon God's revealed word.

How Is God's Will Known?

Scripture consistently gives the same answer.

God reveals His will.

People are expected to hear it, understand it, and obey it.

Examples include:

- **Deuteronomy 29:29** — “The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but those that are revealed belong to us...”
- **Psalms 119:105** — “Your word is a lamp to walk by...”
- **John 12:48** — Jesus says His words will judge mankind.
- **2 Timothy 3:16–17** — Scripture equips God's people for every good work.
- **Jude 3** — “the faith that was once for all entrusted to the saints.”

The pattern is revelation first, then faith, then obedience.

Correspondence Across Scripture

Event	Human Reasoning	God's Revelation	Outcome
Uzzah	Keep the Ark from falling	Carry it by poles on Levite shoulders	Judgment
Nadab and Abihu	Offer worship	Offer only what God commanded	Judgment
Saul	Better sacrifice	Destroy everything devoted to destruction	Kingdom rejected
Moses	Strike again	Speak to the rock	Excluded from Canaan
Jeroboam	Easier worship	Worship where and how God directed	National apostasy
Corinthians	Common meal	Discern the Lord's body	Divine discipline
Pharisees	Preserve tradition	Keep God's command	Worship in vain

Early Christian Perspective

The early Christian writers repeatedly stressed that worship must conform to what Christ and the apostles delivered, not to human innovation.

Clement of Rome (late first century) argued that God has established an order for worship and service, and believers should not rearrange it according to personal preference (1 Clement 40–44).

Ignatius of Antioch emphasized unity under apostolic teaching rather than private judgment. For him, the church's life was to remain ordered according to what had been handed down.

These writers did not teach salvation by flawless ritual. Rather, they taught that love for God is shown by respecting His revealed order.

Restoration Theology Perspective

Alexander Campbell often argued that Scripture distinguishes between **expedients** and **institutions**.

- An **institution** is something God has established. Humans have no authority to change it.
- An **expedient** is a lawful aid that helps carry out what God has commanded without changing its nature.

Applied to Uzzah:

- Carrying the Ark by Levites with poles was God's institution.
- Building a better road or organizing the procession could have been expedients.
- Replacing God's method with a cart was not an expedient. It altered the revealed pattern.

This distinction reflects the New Testament concern that Christians must not *"go beyond what is written"* (1 Corinthians 4:6) or substitute human wisdom for God's instruction.

Conclusion

Uzzah's death is not a lesson about an angry God waiting to punish mistakes. It is a lesson about God's holiness and man's tendency to presume.

Throughout Scripture, the same pattern appears:

- God reveals His will.
- People improve it, simplify it, or adapt it.
- Their motives may be sincere.
- But sincerity cannot replace revelation.
- Faith is shown by trusting God's wisdom above our own.

The central question of worship and teaching is not, **"Will this work?"** or **"Do we mean well?"** The central question is, **"Has God spoken?"**

This is the "obedience of faith" that frames Paul's teaching in Romans. Faith does not invent its own path to God. Faith hears God's word, trusts His wisdom, and walks in the way He has revealed.